

RANRAN LI

Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security and Law
Günterstalstraße 73, 79100 Freiburg im Breisgau

Website: ranranli.net; Email: r.li@cs.l.mpg.de

[Website](#) | [MPI page](#) | [Google Scholar](#) | [ORCID](#) | [LinkedIn](#)

ACADEMIC POSITION

2025 – Postdoc researcher (Humboldt Postdoc Fellow since 2026)
Department of Criminology, Host: Jean-Louis van Gelder
Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security, and Law, Germany

EDUCATION

2020 – 2025 PhD in Personality Psychology
Dissertation: Unlocking Personality: How situational strength and situational affordances shape behavioral expression (Supervisors: Reinout E. de Vries, Daniel Balliet, Isabel Thielmann). <https://doi.org/10.5463/thesis.1256>
Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, Netherlands

2024 – 25 PhD research visit, *Max Planck Institute for the Study of Crime, Security, and Law*

2018 – 2020 Research Master's in Psychology (with merit)
University of Amsterdam, Netherlands

2016 – 17 Global Exchange, *University of Münster, Germany*

2014 – 2018 BSc in Psychology (distinction)
Soochow University, Taiwan

RESEARCH STATEMENT

With the belief that ‘*Serious inquiry into human nature is not a luxury*,’ I study how personality traits and situational factors interact to shape human behavior, in particular, prosocial and moral behavior. I am currently applying this **person–situation interaction perspective** to the study of bystander intervention (i.e., how people remain prosocial when situations make it difficult to do so). I adopt rigorous empirical methods and am drawn to theoretical integration.

While psychology remains my ‘*Forever Moonlight*’ and intellectual foundation, I have interdisciplinary interests and pursuits. At present, I am actively bridging psychology with criminology, behavioral economics, and sociocultural perspectives. I am additionally interested in philosophy of science (meta-science) and computational social science. I see myself as a bridger and builder across disciplines.

Support good science – open, rigorous, and trustworthy science – always on the way.

PUBLICATIONS

2026

Li, R., De Vries, R. E., Van Gelder, J.-L. (2026). Entangled pathways to delinquency: An integrative process model of personality, situations, and macro-structures. *Zeitschrift für Psychologie*.

◇ Co-organizing a panel at the European Society of Criminology (ESC), Warsaw, Sept 2026, “Virtual Reality as a window into crime: Personality, situations, and psychological processes”

{person-situation processes}

Ye, Z., Long, F., Feng, R., van Dijk, W., & **Li, R.** (2026). People feel but don't tell: Dispositional honesty and emotional responses to others' (mis)fortunes. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 126, 104966. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2026.104966>

{empathy}

{method: vignette; diary; real-time interaction}

2025

Li, R., & Wilt, J. A. (2025). Situated selves: A cyclical model of personality expression in context. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 102104. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2025.102104>

{person-situation processes}

Van Gelder, J.-L., **Li, R.**, Wiechert, S., & Frankenhuys, W. E. (2025). Short-term mindsets: Beyond traits and self-regulation. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 102112. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.copsyc.2025.102112>

Li, R., & Zettler, I. (2025). Entangled Minds: A roadmap for bridging cultural and personality psychology research. *Personality Science*, 6. <https://doi.org/10.1177/27000710251388772>

{personality x cultural psychology}

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. E. (2025). Trait activation in daily life: Comparing two perspectives on person-situation interactions. *Journal of Research in Personality*, 104689. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jrp.2025.104689>

◇ Received SeedCorn Research Grant €3,000 for the project, Kurt Lewin Institute

◇ Organized a symposium at the International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS), Brussels, Mar 2023, “Trait and situation activation in daily life and organizational settings”

{personality expression}

{method: diary study}

2024

Li, R., Balliet, D., Thielmann, I., & De Vries, R. E. (2024). Revisiting situational strength: Do strong situations restrict variance in behaviors? *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspi0000475>

◇ Received multiple awards for the paper, including Best Paper Award @ Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology conference, Tilburg, Netherlands (2022), Runner-up for the Best Paper Award, Kurt Lewin Institute, Netherlands (2024), and Best Student Presentation Award at the International Conference on Social Dilemmas, Leiden, Netherlands (2024).

◇ Chaired a methodological session “Methodological Advances in OB research” at the Academy of Management (AOM), Boston, Aug 2023:

{prosocial behavior}

{method: social dilemma games; meta-analysis}

2023

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. E. (2023). Development of the Generic Situational Strength (GSS) scale: Measuring situational strength across contexts. In L. R. Ford & T. A. Scandura (Eds.), *The SAGE Handbook of Survey Development and Application*.
<https://doi.org/10.4135/9781529617757.n35>

{method: scale development}

Li, R. Revisiting person–situation interactionism. *Nature Reviews Psychology*, 2, 6 (2023).
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s44159-022-00139-8>

{person-situation processes}

> Manuscripts in the pipeline

Li, R., Thielmann, I., Balliet, D., & De Vries, R. (R&R 2nd round). When dishonesty pays off: Incentives foster trait activation of Honesty-Humility.

◇ Received iBBA Online Experiment Grant €2,500, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam

{dishonesty}

{method: experimental cheating games}

Li, R., Knabe, M., Derakhshan, S., Arui, A.-K., & Van Gelder, J.-L. (under review). Beyond immersion and presence: Rethinking validity in Virtual Reality criminology.

{method: Virtual Reality}

He, Y., & **Li, R.** (under review). Helping in the dark: Toward a science of prosociality under risk.

He, Y., & **Li, R.** (under review). Prosociality under risk: A conceptual synthesis and roadmap for future research.

{prosocial behavior}

> Work in progress

Li, R., De Vries, R. E., Barnum, T., Herman, S., Tisdall, L., Van Gelder, J.-L. A trait–state model of reactive guardianship: Psychological pathways to bystander intervention. *Manuscript in prep.*

{bystander intervention}

{method: Virtual Reality}

Li, R., Van Gelder, J.-L., & De Vries, R. E. Who goes where and why? A meta-analytic review of personality and situation selection. *Manuscript in prep.*

{person-situation processes}

Umashev, N., **Li, R.**, Rusch, H. Agent incentives: How agents trade off incentives and exploitation risk in principal selection. *Manuscript in prep.*

{personality & exploitation}
{method: sequential experimental games}

van Lissa, C., Ballou, N., **Li, R.**, et al. Self-determination theory: Theory specification. *Manuscript in prep.*

{method: formal theory}

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Slides/posters available at osf.io/a83tv

Panel Co-organizer: European Society of Criminology (ESC), Warsaw, Sept 2026: “Virtual Reality as a window into crime: Personality, situations, and psychological processes”

Symposium Organizer: International Convention of Psychological Science (ICPS), Brussels, Mar 2023: “Trait and situation activation in daily life and organizational settings”

Session Moderator: Academy of Management (AOM), Boston, Aug 2023: “Methodological Advances in OB Research”

Other presentations (selected):

Personality Psychology (& Psychology General)	European Conference of Personality (ECP) ^{1,2,3} ; Summer School of Personality Science (SSPS) ³ ; Association for Research in Personality (ARP) conference; Differentielle Psychologie (DPPD) conference; Kurt Lewin Institute (KLI) Conference; German Psychological Science Congress (DGPs)	¹ Edinburgh, July 2026; ² Berlin, Aug 2024; ³ Madrid, Aug 2022; Evanston, July 2023;
Criminology	European Society of Criminology (ESC) conference; American Society of Criminology (ASC) conference;	Kassel, Sept 2025; Utrecht, April 2024; Luxembourg, Sept 2026; Warsaw, Sept 2026 Washington DC, Nov 2025
Behavioral Economics/ Interdisciplinary	International Conference on Social Dilemmas (ICSD); Cognition, Behavior, & Evolution Network (CBEN) conference ^{1,2} ; Matterhorn Symposium;	Leiden, July 2024; ¹ Maastricht, Oct 2024; ² Leiden, April 2026; Brig, Switzerland, Sept 2025;
Management	Academy of Management (AOM) conference; Working community of Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology (WAOP) ^{1,2} ,	Boston 2023; ¹ Tilburg, Nov 2022; ² Groningen, Nov 2023
Others: VR, Tech	XR meeting; VIRTUES VR meeting; Machine+Behavior conference; Summer Institute Computational Social Science	Würzburg, Oct 2025; Hagen, Sept 2025; Berlin, May 2026; Rotterdam, June 2022.

GRANTS, AWARDS

Grants/Fellowships

- 2026 **Humboldt Postdoc Fellowship:** two-year fellowship (approx. €90k)
- 2025 **Chinese Government Award for Outstanding PhDs:** \$6,000
- 2024 **DAAD (German Academic Exchange Service) Research Grant:** Bi-nationally Supervised Doctoral Degrees, €1,300*7 months
- 2024 **iBBA Online Experiment Grant** €2,500, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam
- 2021 **Kurt Lewin Institute (KLI) SeedCorn Research Grant** €3,000

Awards

- 2024 **Best Student Presentation Award**, International Conference on Social Dilemmas (ICSD), Leiden, Netherlands
- 2024 **Runner-up for the Best Paper Award**, Kurt Lewin Institute, Netherlands
- 2022 **Best Paper Award**, Working community of Dutch Work & Organizational Psychology (WAOP) conference, Tilburg, Netherlands

Scholarship

- 2024 Travel Grant European Conference of Personality (ECP)
- 2023 Academy of Management (AOM) conference registration scholarship
- 2017 DAAD (German Grant Institute) - STIBET fellowship
- 2014 - 2018 Soochow University Scholarship for students with outstanding academic performance (*7 times); Franklin Scholarships for Dual Degree of Soochow University (*3 times). Sum up to NT\$ 400,000 ($\approx 12,680\text{€}$)

REVIEWING

Personality and Social Psychology Review: *Emerging Editorial Board* (2023–2025; 4);
 European Journal of Personality (4);
 Collabra: Psychology (1);
 Health Psychology (1);
 Zeitschrift für Psychologie (1);
 Current Research in Ecological and Social Psychology (1);
 Social Psychology (1);
 European Journal on Criminal Policy and Research (1);
 SAGE Handbook of Survey Development and Application (1).

TEACHING

Thesis supervision Master thesis supervision and assessment, *Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam*
 Sebastiaan Schulter (2023-2024),
 Savannah Huxtable (2023-2024),
 Daria Hovorukha (student from Ukraine, 2022-2023),
 Lara Vogel (2022-2023),
 Zihan Wang (2022-2023),
 Chenyu Tang (2021-2022),
 Sofia Canelos (2021-2022),
 Nora Choa (2020-2022).
 Bachelor thesis supervision, *Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam*
 Roe Bakker (2021-2022).

Guest Lecture Invited Guest Lecture “Personality, Situations, Behavior in Organizational Settings”, Feb 2024, *Amsterdam Business School, University of Amsterdam*

Grading Grading master’s course ‘Personality at Work’, *Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam*
 Grading bachelor’s course ‘Methodological Research Projects’, *University of Amsterdam, Amsterdam Business School*

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

Translations for cross-cultural projects @*Psychological Science Accelerator* (and colleagues’) to enhance the generalizability of psychological science.

Columnist: Promote science communication in personality-social psychology, promote methodological rigor in scientific practices. Selected blogs include:

- ❖ The Soul of Science: On integrity in an age of pragmatic academia. (2025).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/soul-of-science.html> (English).
- ❖ How situational settings influence behavior: New insights from behavioral research. (2024).
 Kudos: American Psychological Association (APA) showcases.
<https://www.growkudos.com/publications/10.1037%252Fpsi0000475/>
- ❖ Recent Development in Personality Assessment. (2022). Amsterdam Leadership Lab.
<https://www.amsterdamleadershiplab.nl/recent-development-in-personality-assessment>
- ❖ AOM 2020 Reflections: Insights from the Academy of Management Annual Meeting. (2020).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/aom2020.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/iVOEuHauUwGY9PYO7S6aSw> (Chinese)
- ❖ The Limitations of p -value and Bayesian hypothesis testing. (2019).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/pvalue-bayes.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/sTBc3Yvd7aBpFt4Dmt7r9Q> (Chinese).
- ❖ Big Data Analytics in Psychology and Management Research. (2020).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/bigdata.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/zg01AE3mKxQ7HWQkwTtBDA> (Chinese).

- ❖ Is Psychology a useless discipline? (2020) (Chinese)
- ❖ Questionable Research Practices (QRPs) in Social Science Research. (2021).
<https://ranranli.net/blogs/qtps.html> (English);
<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/1fDl5gUYtRjIs2bHHXJmBA> (Chinese)